On nonviolence – its philosophy and its methods, and how it combines with other tools for conflict transformation

Nonviolence is a broad discipline that centres on struggles for socio-political change. It carries with it a specific philosophy, sets of principles, and a number of concrete methods. Nonviolent action for change has been present throughout all of human history, in all different societies, in big or small conflicts, and has countless times been used to achieve great advances for more just, inclusive and peaceful societies. As a concept, it has become more established throughout the 20th century, however, it still remains a rather diffuse and debated discipline among different practitioners and scholars.[1]

Nonviolence is deeply embedded in SweFOR's vision and ways of working. Combined with methods of peacebuilding (such as dialogue), nonviolence provides a very useful set of tools when fighting oppression and transforming conflicts.

SweFOR's definition of nonviolence

The term nonviolence is based on a negation, being "not violence". However, the word is written as one word: *nonviolence*, at it is something more than just "not violence". Stellan Vinthagen, a Swedish researcher on resistance studies, has coined the following definition which represents the most broad conceptualization of the term:

Against violence + without violence = nonviolence[2]

According to this idea, for something to be classified as *nonviolence* or *nonviolent*, it needs to work actively against violence or oppression, as well as use methods that are not violent

[1] Terminology can differ – *nonviolent action, people power, civil resistance*, etc. they are all associated to the same type of movements or methods. However, as SweFOR sees it, the term *nonviolence* represents not only the methods for sociopolitical struggle, but also some fundamental philosophical and ideological aspects of moral.

[2] Vinthagen Stellan (2015) A Theory of Nonviolent Action – How Civil Resistance Works " ZED Books,

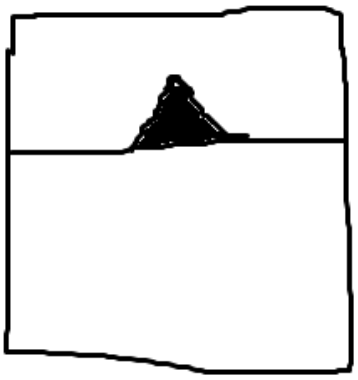
themselves. If someone tries to stop violence by throwing a person in prison or threatening them with beatings, it cannot be described as nonviolence. Likewise, by not using violence, but also not actively resisting oppression or injustice, it cannot be described as nonviolence. Nonviolence requires active steps to stop oppression or violence, without creating new expressions of violence or oppression.

As this text will go deeper into nonviolence as a discipline, it will become clear that the above definition represents a suitable first glance at the concept. However, it does not capture the other key aspects of nonviolence, as SweFOR understands them. For example, there is a unique resistance-oriented character of nonviolence, which will become clear in the section about peacebuilding.

How to understand violence

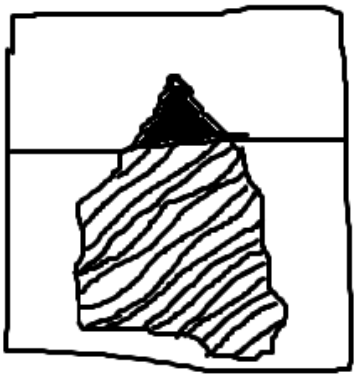
On a conceptual level, it is evident that Nonviolence is closely linked to *violence*. *Violence* as a term in itself will here simply be defined as *harm that is caused on a living being, a person or group*. By digging deeper into the concept of violence, we can understand more about nonviolence and its perspectives.

A Norwegian researcher named Johan Galtung has introduced a model called ”levels of violence”, often presented in the shape of an iceberg[3]. In SweFOR’s work in the Maghreb region, the model has been translated into a more common natural feature – a desert mountain. *The desert mountain* represents the complexity of violence, as it exists in different levels that interconnect and feed on each other.

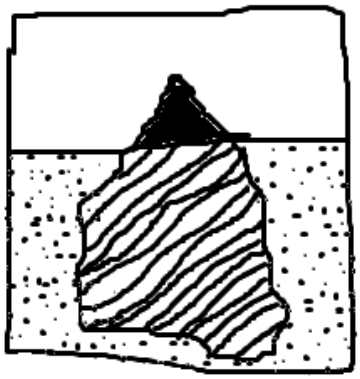


The top of the mountain that is visible to the eye represents **direct violence**. In this type of violence, it is normally easy to identify both victims and perpetrators. Direct violence can be physical violence, ranging from milder forms like slapping someone, to seriously hurting or killing someone. Direct violence can also be sexual, psychological, or verbal violence. With direct violence, it is relatively easy for to see it and identify what happens, who is doing something harmful and who is being subjected to it – clear perpetrators and clear victims. As the top of the desert mountain is easy to see for everyone, it therefore represents direct violence and visible violence.

[3] Galtung, johan (1969) Violence, peace and peace research, International Peace Research Institute Oslo



What is not visible but present is the part of the mountain that is under the sand. This part is far bigger than the part that is visible above the ground. This represents the big harmful structures that exist in societies – Galtung calls it **structural violence**. Examples of structural violence can include economic inequality, colonial power-structures, unequal gender roles, unjust laws that discriminate certain groups, etc. These structures are hard to point at directly, as they are not physically visible in their essence, but rather embedded within societies. Ultimately, structural violence leads to more suffering and death than direct violence. Millions of people get hurt, traumatized or die from unjust, hurtful structural violence – for example, hunger, treatable illnesses, substance abuse or death when migrating, In terms of its effects, structural violence leads to suffering and deaths, but in contrast to direct violence, the perpetrators of the structural violence are rarely visible. Structural violence is often an indirect result of political decisions or the lack of political decisions. Also, in societies and groups affected by structural violence, direct violence is often more common. The hidden underground part of the mountain symbolizes structural violence, as it is not easy to see, and is often forgotten about.



Lastly, the model contains a third type of violence, symbolised by the sand that covers the underground rock – **cultural violence**. In the same way that the sand covers the rock, our own culture, norms and language often cover the unjust structures in our own societies, making them invisible to us or just making us accepting them as something normal. One example is stereotypes about certain groups, that often legitimizes discrimination in different forms, like racism, sexism or homophobia. Jokes and humour also plays an important role here, as they often build on stereotypes of different groups, and can build a tolerance and acceptance for discrimination based on the same negative stereotypes. This level of violence is very easy to find close to oneself, as most cultures and paradigms tend to build shared ideas about identities and norms – “us and them”. Often we are ourselves carriers of norms, language and conceptions that legitimize some types of structural violence. The sand in the ground around the mountain symbolizes cultural violence, as it hides the unjust structures – without the sand, the structural violence would be easier to identify and criticize.

As is visible in the above description, the three levels of violence interconnect and interact in many places – cultural violence normalize ideas and attitudes which leads to discrimination and inequalities, that gives less opportunities to live a long and healthy lives. The suffering and struggle of poverty and marginalization also leads some groups to being subjected to different forms of direct violence, like harassment from authorities or being the worst affected of high levels of criminality or in situations of war.

This theory and model can lead us to believe that almost everything around us leads to violence, and interpreting it too rigidly can indeed lead us to exhaustion and fatigue. Instead of this, we can use it to understand how different levels of violence interact and that violence and oppression is complex and multidimensional. It is also a good step to understand the philosophy of nonviolence. As violence on different levels is so present in our societies, nonviolence clearly

manifests in itself a way of breaking many cycles of violence, and creating an alternative way of reaching peace, dignity and coexistence in society, by using peaceful and constructive means.

Nonviolence philosophy - being a good force as a counterpoint to violence

Talking about violence leads us into the core philosophies of nonviolence being seen as a morally and strategically superior path to change in relation to the violent ways. Famous leaders like Mohandas Gandhi and Martin Luther King Jr. both built their philosophy and struggle on this aspect, and have spread ideas that have inspired many nonviolent actors.

Ghandi, being an Indian activist leading the anticolonial struggle against the British colonial rule in the early 20th century was a true pioneer of nonviolence. He helped to develop many of its most influential ideas, and helped to spread them across the world. He talked about nonviolence as the truth and the place of the love and heart of people, something good that exist deep within a person. As a step in growing as a nonviolent actor, he argued for the need to eradicate hate from our hearts, as he saw that violence was something than corrupts from within and takes people away from their true potential and deepest needs. Hence, he and many of his followers were deeply morally and philosophically invested in the importance of being and living nonviolently in a holistic way. Being a practicing Hindu, nonviolence corresponded well with his understanding of his religion. One important implication of this philosophy was that it was the oppressive acts that was being fought and not the individual who was doing the oppression. The British soldiers were not the enemy, but the colonial system behind them was. Connected to this, Ghandi did not shy away from **escalating conflict in a nonviolent way**, like using economic pressure, massive civil disobedience and other forms of active struggle to achieve his movements goals, while simultaneous keeping channels open for dialogue with his opponent - being respectful to the individuals he was approaching yet being firm in his struggle. Gandhi's deep devotion to the nonviolent path, his ability to mobilize many people, combined with a long nonviolent struggle in which various tactics were used lead not only to the British Empire leaving India, but also to his principles and ideas spreading to other countries fighting for their decolonization and demanding rights – like South Africa and The United States

Martin Luther King Jr. was a nonviolent leader who was inspired by Gandhi and took his teachings further. King was active in the civil rights movement in the United States, and he also built his movement on the deep belief in nonviolent philosophy and strategy. Being a black religious leader struggling against racial discrimination and the violence committed against black people in the US, King, like Gandhi, also talked about the deep good, true and human values as a core of nonviolent struggle, and connected it to his Christian belief. However, he and his movement further developed the strategic strength of the nonviolent approach – something that has later been referred to as *political jiu-jitsu* – a martial art where the opponent's strength and weight is turned against themselves. By always staying nonviolent and peaceful, especially when being beaten and assaulted by the police forces or racist mobs, the movement built a strong image of being victims of unjust treatment, which slowly got them visibility and sympathy in society

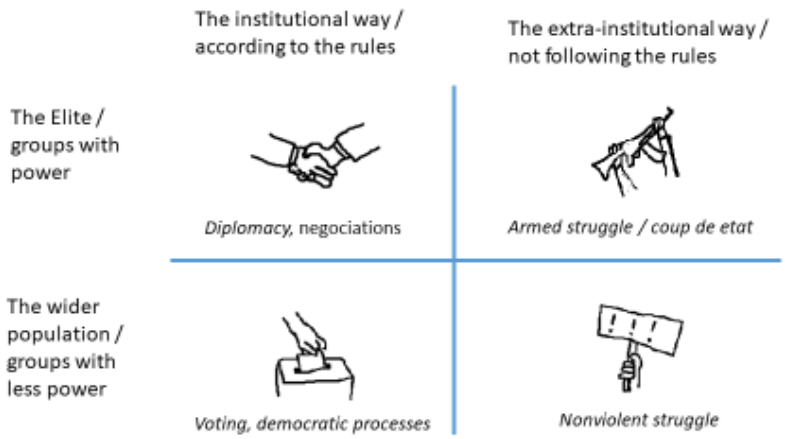
while delegitimizing the groups that used violence against them. This later lead to a strengthened political demand for important legal reforms. One important feature of the civil rights movement's nonviolent struggle was the emphasis on preparation and training so that the activists were prepared to handle scary and violent confrontations using peaceful tactics, even when being attacked.

These two figures both highlights how deep moral convictions based in nonviolent philosophy can interconnect with religious faith, as well as with the strategic approach and tactics which combined ultimately made their movements successful.

A struggle to change status quo

When trying to understand nonviolence as a discipline and as a method for social change, another important aspect to highlight is its focus on making groups with less power build strength in order to challenge status-quo, even when there is a steep power imbalance. This is something important to nonviolence as a discipline, as it actively works to change power balances, and putting pressure on the opponent without using or threatening to use violence. Briefly put, nonviolence has an empowering potential that strengthens the powerless.

In the below diagram, we have used a model created by the Swedish researcher Isak Svensson to examine different ways of reaching a regime change depending on who the actor is, and if it works inside or outside of existing institutional frameworks, or to say – by abiding to the rules of the system or not.



Isak Svensson, Scholar in peace and conflict studies University of Uppsala, Sweden.

As you can see, the institutional ways for an elite (or relatively powerful group in society) to create change is normally to use diplomacy and negotiations to slowly agree on reforms with the leading figures. This assumes that there is a relatively well balanced power distribution between the groups/parties engaging in negotiation or diplomacy. Also, in situations where a

functioning democratic system is in place, the citizens can also use institutional means such as voting in elections to replace the leadership or voice their will about reforms, provided that the leading powers would respect this demand. If not being listened to, both elite groups and the wider population can choose to act outside of the institutional ways, or chose to "not follow the rules". Elite groups that are not getting their demands met, for example from a dictator, can attempt to do a coup d'état , meaning to force a leader to hand over power using military or political methods. When the broader population chooses to go outside of the institutions to demand change, it is best done through nonviolent struggle – using nonviolent means to put pressure on the leadership to change.

When talking about the choice to not use violence, there are more than just moral or personal reasons for groups to choose nonviolent methods instead of violent methods. Researchers Erika Chenoweth and Maria J. Stephan have pointed out how much more effective and sustainable the nonviolent struggles have been historically compared to violent struggles. The fact that violent struggles tend to build on young men that take up arms means that they tend to exclude large parts of society, who will support the struggle to a lesser extent. Also, the fact that using violence is destructive by nature, as it leads to suffering, death and destruction, often through human rights violations from all sides and lowered levels of trust in society between different groups, means that it has had a lower success-rate than broad nonviolent struggles that has the potential to be very inclusive, appealing and accessible for broad segments of society – young and old, men and women, etc.[4]

The typical methods of nonviolence

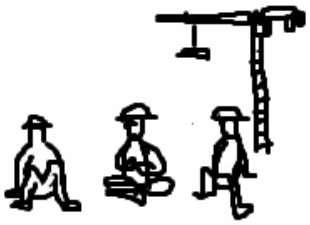
Researcher and nonviolence activist Gene Sharp has made an overview of the most common nonviolent methods and put them into three overall "categories" of activities: expressions, non-cooperation and interventions.[5] Each category includes a number of tactics and activities that a group can use to push for a change to happen. Even though all methods are abstaining from violence, many can indeed be confrontative and directly challenge power.

Nonviolent protest and persuasion are typical methods like demonstrations or campaigns, where individuals or groups express messages in a clear and nonviolent way. The messages can be communicated in different ways, like slogans, written statements or in songs, and the more attention they get, the bigger effect they can have. The messages can be either in support of something or against something, to persuade a power holder of doing or abstaining from doing something.

[4] Erica Chenoweth and Maria J. Stephan (2012) *Why Civil Resistance Works -The Strategic Logic of Nonviolent Conflict.* Columbia University Press

[5] Sharp, Gene (1994). From dictatorship to democracy: A conceptual framework for liberation (1st English language ed.). Bangkok, Thailand: Committee for the Restoration of Democracy in Burma

Social, economical or political non-cooperation are methods where individuals or group refrain from doing what they normally do in order to put pressure on their adversaries, for the purpose of creating change. Typical examples are strikes where workers refuse to work in order to demand something from their companies, or boycotts where consumers avoid certain products to make a brand stop selling certain harmful products. The desired goal of a non-cooperation can differ, but is often about forcing an actor to agree on certain demands by using the existing leverage you have over them.



Nonviolent interventions are the category of methods where individuals or groups choose to do something to actively disrupt something that they see is negative. For example, blocking the way for an excavator before it tears down a nice old tree. It can also be the choice to create and use alternative structures outside of the conventional ones, like self-organize independently and try to create a direct change that is needed – like creating your own school system outside of a discriminatory school system. Interventions like these are about making a change happen in a direct way.

Each type of method can be used *against something*, or *for something*; meaning either to punish or threaten the opponent, or to create, encourage or support something it sees as positive. Also, bigger campaigns often build on combinations of all these three types of methods.

Comparing nonviolence to peacebuilding as approaches for conflict transformation

To better understand nonviolence and its methods for social change, it is useful to examine it in relation to peacebuilding, which is a separate yet related discipline for social-political change and conflict transformation, which has been covered in our earlier handout.

Peacebuilding focuses on addressing structural issues, grievances of the past and long-term relationships between parties or groups in conflict, in order to strengthen negative peace and develop positive peace. Discussions about peacebuilding generally emphasize.

Dialogue is an example of a typical peacebuilding method, where different positions are represented and where participants jointly examine the issue from all actors' perspectives while building relations between them. Other typical peacebuilding methods are negotiation, reconciliation, different levels of institution-building and structural reform.

Typical methods of peacebuilding
Dialogue – a practice of communication to build understanding and relations with the opposing side of the conflict. The emphasis is on listening and sharing, not on reaching agreement. **Negotiation** – a practice of reaching difficult agreements between opponents. **Reconciliation** – a practice of building and rebuilding relations between groups during or after a destructive conflict has damaged those relations. **Capacity-building of different levels of institutions** – broadly, peacebuilding often centres on building the capacity of different important societal institutions, both governing entities and civil institutions that has important impact locally, nationally or regionally. **Structural reform** – the processes of strengthening and reforming laws, constitution, and organisations, regulating and safeguarding the formalization of development- and peace initiatives and their sustainability.

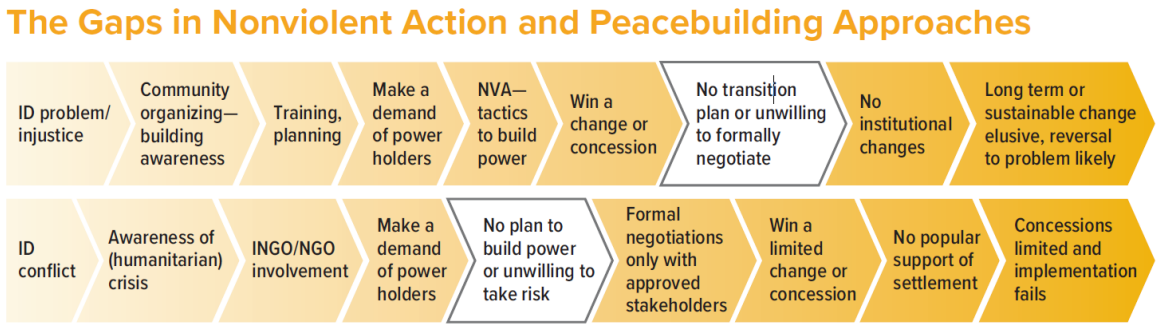
When peacebuilding is put next to nonviolence some things become visible in the different approaches, which helps distinguishing both more clearly.

First, it should be mentioned that both nonviolence and peacebuilding are generally working for a just and peaceful society using peaceful means, where violence cannot be a tool to achieve this change. According to Stellan Vinthagen's broad definition of nonviolence, both nonviolence and peacebuilding are both against violence and not using violence. If we have this in mind, the two disciplines however have some important differences:

- Whereas nonviolence tends to focus on empowering a weaker group and to change an unjust and oppressive status quo, peacebuilding tends to look for the needs of all the so-called *stakeholders*, meaning that every group that is part in the conflict needs to be included in the solution, both weaker and stronger parties.
- Methods typically associated with nonviolence tend to have a confrontational function of building power and putting pressure on the actors in power, whereas peacebuilding methods try to unify by build shared understanding and solutions to a problem, not using confrontation nor pushing any of the actor.

The strength of nonviolent action is that it builds and shifts power by heightening awareness and participation in the process of applying social, economic, and political pressure, so that powerful groups cannot ignore the needs and interests of other groups in society. In short, it balances power in conflicts. The weakness of nonviolent action is that balancing power and creating pressure for change alone may not lead to sustainable changes.

The typical nonviolent change campaign, provided that it is strong and successfully executed, often encounters its biggest challenges once it has won a change or concession – there is often lack of transitions plans or will to formally negotiate with the ruling power, which limits the change process to have an impact on the institutional level, which in turn risks making the achievements short-lived.



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The strength of peacebuilding is that it uses inclusive processes to develop solutions that satisfy the interests of all groups .It is focused on relationships. Peacebuilding processes like community-led dialogues can be helpful within a nonviolent campaign or movement, to help build strong coalitions. Dialogue and negotiation are also helpful to develop creative solutions and negotiate a sustainable outcome between a nonviolent movement and external stakeholders. The weakness of peacebuilding processes is that dialogue and negotiation are often ineffective if there is a significant power imbalance between groups.

As visible in the graphic above, peacebuilding processes often loses power mid-way, as it can often succeed in gathering all stakeholders to talk, but the actors involved often have a limited mandate and cannot force any other actors involved to implement changes or accept all other actors – making the results of dialogues or negotiations less legitimate or powerful.

The point to make is that none of the separate approaches normally succeed with their aim without mixing with the other method, hence peacebuilding and nonviolence are complementary approaches to sociopolitical change.

In reality many actors are in fact using both nonviolent methods and peacebuilding methods, and some methods are actually hard to place in just one of the two categories. The distinction between the two types is important from a pedagogical point of view, as it clarifies the unique strength of using different approaches.

The Curle diagram – how to best combine nonviolent methods and peacebuilding

So if the methods are so different, how are we supposed to best combine them? The English peacebuilder and activist Adam Curle developed a model that is helpful when trying to understand what type of approach that is useful when trying to bring change in a society.

Curle Diagram

Conflict Transformation Process			
Violence and Injustice ---------- Peace and Justice			
Balanced Power		**Conflict Settlement:** Tactics create pressure on group in power to convert, persuade, or accommodate interests of other groups through negotiations or mediation.	**Sustainable Peace and Justice:** Principled negotiation addresses main interests of all groups.
Unbalanced Power	**Latent Conflict:** Community organizing, coalition building, capacity building, conscientization, conflict assessment, early warning and preventive diplomacy and dialogue to increase awareness of the need for change.	**Overt Conflict:** Nonviolent action to broaden public awareness and balance power between groups; human rights monitoring to deepen understanding of the problem; and peacekeeping and protection of civilian programs to reduce level of violence.	
Low Awareness of Issues ---------- High Awareness			

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The Curle diagram is a roadmap-tool that looks at some aspects of a change process, and according to this, you can identify both the stage of the process, as well as what type of tactics that can be beneficial to move forward, towards a peaceful and just solution of the issue.

The aspects to look at along the sides are the following:

- **The balance of power**: is power balanced between the groups in question, or is one group/ actor dominant?
- **The level of violence & injustice** – are there violent repression or confrontations, including both direct violence and structural violence?. Or is there less violence and repression? Take note here that "violence and injustice" can be understood through Galtung's model as *direct and structural violence.*
- **Awareness of the issues** - is the population in the society aware of the issues that the change process is about? Does the public know what types of conflicts or injustices are going on, and what is their attitude towards them, are they motivated to support the issue?

By looking at these three aspects of the situation, we first identify where we are in the diagram:

- **Latent or "hidden" conflict:** a stage characterized by high levels of violence and injustice against some groups, , whereas the rest of the population is not aware of nor engaged in the problem. Also, the power is not balanced. Nonviolent methods for mobilizing bigger groups can be used, combined with peacebuilding tools such as collaborative planning through dialogue and strengthening relations within the mobilizing group.
- **Overt or "open" conflict:** at this stage, there is a greater public awareness and support for the issue, while there is still a significant level of violence and injustice, and power remains unbalanced. Nonviolent methods can be used to escalate conflict and put pressure on the power holders.
- **Conflict settlement:** a stage where power has been somewhat balanced and awareness of the issue has been spread. There is a possibility to achieve change, either by persuasion or by forcing the powerful actor to play along. In this stage, it is often the powerful group that accommodates the interests of the other groups. Peacebuilding methods come in handy, as a step to facilitate the negotiations and dialogue sessions between the sides of the conflict.
- **Sustainable peace and justice**: this stage is reached once negotiations have addressed the root causes of a conflict or problem, and policies, institutions and culture is working to protect human rights and promote inclusive governance. Here both peacebuilding tools and nonviolent tools are useful, as the nonviolent mobilization can put continuous public pressure on the power holders to proceed with the negotiations, and as peacebuilding's institution strengthening work will be useful.

Also, in the boxes within the diagram, you can see how the stage of the process can be understood;

1. **Hidden conflict:** there is a low knowledge and/or support for the conflict in the broader population, violence, oppression and injustice is at a high level and power is unbalanced in society. The diagram suggest the following tactics and methods as suitable in this stage; community organizing and coalition building, capacity building, conscientization, conflict assessment and dialogue to increase awareness of the need for change.
2. **Open conflict:** the conflict is relatively well known and somewhat supported within the broader population, power is still unbalanced. The diagram suggest nonviolent methods to broaden public awareness, create support and in that way begin to balance the power.
3. **Conflict settlement:** A situation where the support for the issue within the society is relatively strong and active, hence the power between the movement for change and leaders/opponent has been more balanced. Violence and oppression can still be present, but there is now a possibility to start negotiation. The diagram suggest tactics to create pressure on groups in power to convert, persuade to change, or to accommodate interests of other groups through negotiations or mediation.
4. **Sustainable peace and justice:** A situation where power has been further balanced and awareness and support for the issue further grown in society, and the level of violence

and injustices has gone down in relation to earlier. The moment is now ripe for formal peace processes that aim to address the main interests of all groups involved in the conflict.

As the spinning arrow in the diagram suggests, neither socio-political change nor conflict transformation is linear processes. Many times there are backlashes that reverse the process – levels of violence and repression can go up during a mass mobilization process as the conflict becomes open, or the public's interest and support for an issue can increase and decrease over time. The Curle diagram is a useful tool when conducting *strategic planning* for conflict transformation processes, as it helps us look at our change process from a meta perspective, tells us what type of aspects to be aware of, and indicates what types of methods – both nonviolence and peacebuilding – helps us move forward and upward in the diagram.